Bitburg, she let me know her opinion. She is not one to shout or be critical when she disagrees with me. Most of the time, she'll just go over the points she believes in, perhaps during dinner, then say in her quiet voice something like: "Do you think it's really a good idea for you to do that?" or "I don't think I'd say that anymore if I were you. . . ." Whenever she speaks up like that, I know she's trying to protect me; she isn't trying to interfere with how I do my job, she just wants to keep me out of trouble.

I have always valued Nancy's opinion and, frankly, I'm not sure a man could be a good president without a wife who is willing to express her opinions with the frankness that grows out of a solid marriage. In a good marriage, husband and wife are best friends; if you can't trust your wife to be honest with you, whom can you trust? She'll tell you things nobody else will, sometimes things you don't want to hear, but isn't that how it should be? I wouldn't want a wife who sat across from me at dinner mentally disagreeing with me but afraid to speak up and express an opinion. No, Nancy was my best friend and I wanted to know how she felt.

She argued that my visit to the Bitburg cemetery would be offensive to Jews and make me look insensitive to those who had died in the Holocaust. I told her that once I'd accepted the invitation, I could not embarrass Helmut Kohl by canceling the visit. But that wasn't the only reason I refused to cancel.

I didn't think it was right to keep on punishing every German for the Holocaust, including generations not yet born in the time of Hitler. I don't think all Germans deserve to bear the stigma for everything he did. As I mentioned earlier, during the last days of the war, I saw an Army Signal Corps film with searing images of German villagers being taken to death camps near their homes. They were discovering for the first time what Hitler had done. I knew that from the looks of sickening disbelief and disgust on